

Cons

- This is not a 'display' format, even if you can find codecs to display thumbnails of XCF images in file explorers.
- It's bulky.
- Colour channels are coded in 8 bits (in GIMP 2.8).

Recommended uses

- Saving all GIMP work.

JPG*Pros*

- Compresses the files quite efficiently.
- Is universally supported for display.

Cons

- Compression is 'lossy' and this slightly alters the image data. In case of global changes (colour, contrast, etc), repeated file editing will slowly degrade the image quality.
- At good quality levels, compression is invisible in photography but can be seen (so called 'artefacts') in computer-generated graphics and text.
- It does not support transparency.
- Colour channels are coded on 8 bits.

Recommended uses

- Display of photography.
- Storage of photography.

PNG*Pros*

- Lossless format, and all pixels are kept.
- Supports partial transparency.
- Produces small files with most computer graphics.
- Supported by all browsers.

Cons

- Complex images (photos) are bulky.
- Colour channels are coded in 8 bits.

Recommended uses

- Web page widgets —banners, buttons, frames, etc.
- Computer graphics.
- Screenshots (unless this screenshot is mostly made up of a photo).

GIF*Pros*

- Universally supported for animation.

Cons

- Only 256 colours per image, leading to a blocky look (a modern variant supports 256 colours per frame, but GIMP does not use it).
- Supports transparency but only as fully transparent/fully opaque.

Recommended uses

- Small animated images (in all other still-image uses, PNG is a better alternative, and for bigger animation, modern HTML supports video).

TIFF*Pros*

- Lossless format, and all pixels are kept.
- Colour channels can be coded in 16 bits.
- Can store several images (layers).
- Supported by all image processing software.

Cons

- Can be bulky for complex images.

Recommended uses

- Storage and exchange of high quality images.

Raw images formats: NEF (Nikon), CR2 (Canon), etc*Pros*

- No loss of information from the camera sensor (in theory).
- High-depth colour channels (12- or 14-bit).

Cons

- Proprietary (except DNG).
- Content format can change without notice (with the arrival of new camera models); this can impact support for one's favourite software.
- It's bulky.
- Not suitable for display.

Recommended uses

- Storage of camera output, but a secondary copy in some universal format could be a good idea.

There are of course many other image formats, but these cover most use cases. They can usually be converted easily to any other format, should the need arise.

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